

Making Luke 6:38 Work for You

Prosperity Is Grace Accessed by Faith, Not Wealth Earned by Giving

Turn to Luke 6. We are going to begin again with verse 43, but first we will pray and briefly review where we left off. We have been studying stewardship of temporary money during this short passage of time through life, and we are in Luke 6 because of verse 38:

Give, and it shall be given unto you.

This study on stewardship and our proper use of money is difficult because, of all the things God has provided for us, this is one of the easiest areas to enter into works.

Father, we thank You for Your Word and for prosperity, Your manifold blessings bestowed on us. We thank You for every redemptive right You have given us through the cross. We yield ourselves to the Word and to the greatest Teacher in existence, the Holy Spirit. Teach us what stands between us and the outpouring of citywide revival. We pray for this nation, for the decision-making process in our government, and for our president. We yield ourselves to You and thank You for miracles and manifestations of power. Even more than miracles, we thank You for understanding of Your Word that sets us free and supplies all the power we need to walk free. In Jesus' name. Amen.

We found out, in studying stewardship, that:

Ye know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that, though he was rich, yet for your sakes he became poor,
That ye through his poverty might be rich.

The same way He was made sin so that we might be made the righteousness of God in Christ, He also bore our poverty. He became the poverty of mankind so that through His substitution we might be rich.

Jesus left heaven for the express reason of becoming every broken thing humanity had become through the fall of Adam. He bore our sin, poverty, and lack of peace. He left a place of absolute opulence, extravagant and abundant wealth, where no one even has a sense of lack. Heaven is a lot like here, except wonderful.

By the incarnate birth through the Virgin Mary, God became a man to bear our sins and poverty. He called it an act of grace. That means the wealth He has provided for me cannot be earned or merited. No matter how hard I attempt to earn it, I cannot.

Paul says:

By faith we have access into this grace wherein we stand.

The only access we have to His unmerited favor is by faith. Because part of the instruction of this grace is giving, it is easy to enter into works and legalism. That legalism in giving has made people easy prey for preachers who suppose gain is godliness.

Whether I ever give one penny to the gospel or not, I am still born again by grace. I cannot earn my salvation. I am still going to heaven and inheriting heaven in all its opulence because Jesus bore my poverty and gave me that inheritance. I am a citizen of heaven and an ambassador on the earth. Because my citizenship is in heaven, as a son I have rights to live off the inheritance of my Father while I wait to come of age and receive the full package.

But the access into this grace is by faith. By faith, I give.

Giving Was Instigated to Meet the Giver's Need First

God instigated giving more to meet my need than the needs of the man I am giving to. Elijah and the widow proved that when there was no food to be had. When she gave, God met her needs supernaturally through the rest of the drought with no outside assistance.

Whether I stand or fall is determined by no other man. It is determined by my relationship with the Lord Jesus Christ. Jesus proved that in the wilderness when the boys sowed two fish and five loaves, and He fed five thousand men and their families supernaturally. If God must, He will intervene.

His normal system for the body of Christ is to meet the needs of the body through our giving. But if that system breaks down, it still does not limit God from meeting your needs.

Understanding access to God's prosperity through grace has been one of the most interesting studies in the Word I have ever done. Prosperity is a matter of faith only because faith accesses grace. By faith we have access into the unmerited favor of God bestowed on us through the cross, and that includes prosperity.

Of all the things I have had to survive, the test of prosperity has been the hardest.

Prosperity Tests Loyalty More Severely Than Persecution

When Jesus taught that Satan comes immediately to steal the Word, He used five things. The low-level take-outs are persecutions, afflictions, and cares. The high-level take-outs are the deceitfulness of riches and the lusts of other things.

I have seen something in third-world countries. When people are under oppression, poverty, and persecution, the flesh looks for a way out. If you bring the gospel and promise Jesus and a better life, people will raise their hands. Even under the threat of being beaten, tortured, imprisoned, or killed, the flesh is oppressed and looking for a way out.

But take the same person who held on to Jesus through persecution and transport him into prosperity, free enterprise, and all the possibilities of America, and the test changes. When it comes to pleasure, the flesh does not look for a way out; it looks for a way in.

Your loyalty under prosperity will be more severely tested than you dreamed possible under persecution. I did not say your comfort; I said your loyalty.

Jesus called prosperity choking the Word a thorn seed:

These are they which are sown among thorns...

The deceitfulness of riches... choke the word, and it becometh unfruitful.

The thorn seeds already existed when the Word took root in the ground. The thorn seed, that character deficiency, outgrew the Word and choked it.

Wealth Does Not Create Thorn Seeds; It Exposes Them

I have told you before about the woman whose husband was incredibly wealthy. He abused her, harassed her, and locked her out if she came home late from church. Yet she was faithful under persecution, sitting on the front row.

One day her husband died and left her the fortune. The small Pentecostal church was elated. The pastor had illusions of grandeur. But before long her attendance got shorter while her cars got longer. She moved from the front to the middle, then the back, then special events, then hardly at all.

Many said it would have been better if she had never inherited the money. Wrong.

The money only brought pressure that activated a thorn seed already there. The money did not bring the seed; it activated it. While she did not have money, she did not do anything for God with money. When she had it, she still did not do anything for God with it. She was in the same boat whether she had it or not.

You do not climb into an attic, turn the light on, and say, "Look at all the dirt this light brought." The dirt was already there. The light only exposed it.

You can be smart and get wealthy in America. That does not mean God made you wealthy. If wealth came from God, it will bless the kingdom as much as it blesses you. The difference will show when the devil tries your ground. If your wealth came from God, you and God can hang on to it. If it did not, and the devil decides to eat your lunch, there may be nothing you can do but let it go.

This is why I pressure you so hard to pray in the Holy Ghost. It activates what Jesus talked about when He said, "If you bear fruit, I will purge you so you bear more."

Thorn seeds do not take your salvation away. They are designed to take victory away from the areas where the Word of God should have been free to produce. I would much rather have the Holy Ghost activate those thorn seeds so I can see them, understand them, and have them purged.

Wealth depends on faith accessing His unmerited favor, employing the Word of God, and letting the Holy Ghost purge character flaws and weaknesses that would keep the Word from dominating me. It is not my legalistic dollar placed in an offering last month.

Changing Circumstances Cannot Change the Fruit on Your Tree

Most people, rather than allowing God to purge them, change their circumstances when pressure gets bad. But a grapevine produces grapes, not thorns or brambles. Jesus said every tree is known by its own fruit.

I can blame you for what is happening in my life if it makes me feel better, but I am wrong. Every tree is known by its own fruit.

Many people are like cut-off Christmas trees. We decorate ourselves with ornaments and tinsel and make our appearance in church, but the tree is dead. That is not fruit.

When pressure comes and we begin breaking down, instead of changing, we change our entire set of circumstances. Trouble brews around us because of what we are producing on our tree, so we uproot and move somewhere fresh until our fruit takes us over again.

It is not the prayer center. It is not Brother Roberson. It is not your finances. Every tree is known by its own fruit.

Jesus said the man who digs deep and lays his foundation on the rock of doing His sayings has a guarantee: when the storm comes violently upon the house, the house will still be standing when the storm is over. The man who built on sand experienced the same storm, but his house fell.

The difference between the two men was not the velocity of the storm. They both experienced the same storm. The difference was what their roots were sunk into.

I can teach you about faith, love, peace, righteousness, and all these wonderful forces, but I cannot open you up and put them inside you. But if you hang on long enough, I can teach you how to turn yourself over to the Holy Spirit. He will turn you over to Jesus, and Jesus is all these things.

Jesus said if you bear fruit, He will purge you. He will cut away dead limbs of wrong praying, wrong standing, wrong believing, wrong spending, and wrong sowing until the life of the Father through the vine flows into the fruit-bearing branches. Then let hell blow. When the storm is finished, your house will still be on the rock.

The Rock Is Doing Jesus' Sayings, Not Merely Hearing Them

Luke 6:43 says:

For a good tree bringeth not forth corrupt fruit;
Neither doth a corrupt tree bring forth good fruit.
For every tree is known by his own fruit.
For of thorns men do not gather figs, nor of a bramble bush gather they grapes.
A good man out of the good treasure of his heart bringeth forth that which is good;
And an evil man out of the evil treasure of his heart bringeth forth that which is evil:
For of the abundance of the heart his mouth speaketh.

Then Jesus says:

And why call ye me, Lord, Lord, and do not the things which I say?

The man who comes to Him, hears His sayings, and does them is like the man who dug deep and laid his foundation on a rock. When the flood arose and beat violently on the house, it could not shake it because it was founded on a rock.

The man who hears and does not do is like a man without a foundation who built on the earth. When the stream beat violently on it, immediately it fell, and great was the ruin of that house.

The difference was not the storm. The difference was the foundation. The rock is doing His sayings. Deep digging is digging into revelation knowledge, understanding of His Word, and transformation by the renewing of the mind until you prove the good, acceptable, and perfect will of God.

Godliness With Contentment Keeps Riches From Owning You

Prosperity has more to do with the condition of the heart than I understood. Grace means the things He provided were not accessible to me until Jesus did the impossible, took my place, and made them accessible. The force that gives me access into this grace is faith.

I found out that the opulence of heaven has been made available to me here through grace, and with all my heart I want to understand how to access this grace by faith.

This is when He began to teach me that prosperity has more to do with the conditioning of the heart. That is why He instigated giving to meet my need even more than the need of the person I give to. Giving is an unselfish act that affects the development of my character if it is taught in the right light.

Those who suppose gain is godliness are destitute of truth. Any ministry whose entire foundation is gain is in error. Prosperity is a redemption truth, but it is not a foundational truth.

Paul says:

Godliness with contentment is great gain.

You brought nothing into this world, and it is certain you will carry nothing out. Having food and clothing, learn to be content.

There is nothing wrong with being rich, but if you do not have godliness and contentment, riches will have you. If the devil comes along in a short trial and takes your money, and you do not have godliness with contentment, it will destroy you. But if I have godliness and contentment, I can have a billion dollars one day and nothing the next and still be content.

It does not matter whether the devil tests me with poverty or with opulent wealth. If I have godliness with contentment, I have great gain because neither force will control what I will or will not do for the kingdom of God.

Luke 6:38 Works Through Mercy, Not Self-Interested Giving

Back up to Luke 6:27:

Love your enemies, do good to them which hate you,
Bless them that curse you, and pray for them which despitefully use you.
Unto him that smiteth thee on the one cheek offer also the other;
And him that taketh away thy cloke forbid not to take thy coat also.
Give to every man that asketh of thee;
And of him that taketh away thy goods ask them not again.

Jesus says to do unto others as you would have them do unto you. I used to think that if I treated people the way I wanted to be treated, they would eventually turn around and treat me the same way. I found out differently.

Jesus was not promising that the same people would treat you well. He was telling you how to build your house on the rock. He promised the storm would come. Why warn you about people who slap you, hate you, despitefully use you, and sue you if no storm were coming?

The sayings He is referring to are these: love your enemy, do good to those who hate you, pray for those who despitefully use you, turn the other cheek, and when they sue you, give more.

The promise is that if you are a doer of His sayings, your house will still stand when the storm is over.

He says:

Be ye therefore merciful, as your Father also is merciful.

Judge not, and ye shall not be judged:

Condemn not, and ye shall not be condemned:

Forgive, and ye shall be forgiven:

Give, and it shall be given unto you.

Luke 6:37-38 is one thought. Judge not, condemn not, forgive, and then give.

If I refuse to judge, condemn, and walk in unforgiveness, then when I give, Satan cannot judge my finances. It does not matter what it looks like; it will be given to me. This is about the condition of the heart.

Mercy Strips Satan's Authority to Judge the House

If my tree is not producing that fruit, it is because I have not sown that seed. When I reach for grapes, I do not want to stick my finger on a thorn. But if the thorn is there, it is because I planted the seed for it.

If I spitefully use you when you spitefully use me, I have sown thorns. If you sue me and I fight back in the same spirit, I have sown seed. Every man is known by his own fruit. I cannot blame what is growing in my garden on you.

The only reason I jump in and attempt to fix things with a temporary solution is that I do not have confidence God can bring a permanent solution. I may want to trust Him, but the fruit on my tree proves what is really there.

The devil can sow your field for years until brambles take over. But you can stand before Jesus, take the advocacy of His blood, be cleansed from all unrighteousness, and see what the devil built against you for years crumble in moments. But if you do not replace the vacuum with the Word, those seeds will grow back.

Jesus says the Father is kind to the unthankful and evil. That attribute of His character is called mercy. So He instructs us to do the same.

Instead of judging, condemning, and walking in unforgiveness, have mercy. If a sinner slaps you on the cheek, you are the one showing mercy by turning the other one. If he sues you for everything you have, you are the one showing mercy by not fighting in the same spirit.

You are extending the blood of Jesus across the void to someone who expected only vindication. You are not the loser. Jesus says you will be children of the Most High.

This is where Luke 6:38 operates. While the thief carries your goods out the back door, God can be backing up to your front door, heaping it down, pressing it together, and running it over, because your heart has dictated that wealth is good for getting sinners born again and showing mercy.

The Blind Leading the Blind Means Sinners Need Your Mercy to Find God

Just in case you missed it, Jesus gives a parable:

Can the blind lead the blind?
Shall they not both fall into the ditch?
The disciple is not above his master:
But every one that is perfect shall be as his master.

A parable is something you can understand with your natural mind that illustrates a spiritual application. Blind people following blind people both fall into the ditch. It does not matter how sincere you are if you follow the blind.

The one being taught cannot excel above the one he has subjected himself to. If your teacher is blind, then you will be blind too.

Jesus says to be kind to the unthankful and evil because they are lost and you have the Father. Sinners are kind to one another; you should be capable of more. Extend His mercy to them. When they slap you, turn the other cheek. When they hate you, love them. When they spitefully use you, pray for them. When they sue you, give more.

Why? Because you are their teacher. Outside of you, they do not know where to go to find God. If you are blind, you will lead them into the ditch.

Jesus has asked you to extend mercy, and no matter what the sinner does to you, He has promised to pick up the bill.

If you think prosperity is helping someone coat his Cadillac with gold through your offerings, think again. I do not mind being rich, but I do mind riches shaping my character until I esteem wealth more than the lost.

Can anybody take anything from me? No. Before they are done taking it, I will give it to them.

How do I get to that place? I suggest praying a lot in the Holy Ghost.

Should you be condemned if you are not there? No. But do not stay where you are the rest of your life. There is peace out there. No matter what happens, if you find that peace, He will supply your need according to His riches in glory.

Stand up and worship God.